



Optima Academy Online · An Education Experience Company

Career Research and Decision Making — Teacher Manual

Florida Course 1700380 · One-Semester Elective, 0.5 Credit · Grades 9–12 · Fully Asynchronous (On-Demand) · 5 Modules

Facilitator copy. Contains answer keys, rubrics, and grading guidance. Do not publish to students or attach to the student-facing Canvas course.

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1. HOW THIS COURSE WORKS

A typical lesson

Take Lesson 1.2, *What Are You Optimizing For?*, as the model — every lesson in the build follows the same shape:

1. **Opening reflect widget.** A short, low-stakes multiple-choice check-in with tailored feedback text (ungraded, immediate).
2. **Content blocks.** The six paths framed as parallel doors, then the five "optimizing for" decision questions (cost/debt, time to earning, hands-on vs. academic, structure vs. independence, certainty vs. exploration).
3. **An embedded interactive.** A match-priority-to-path select widget, giving the student practice applying the framework before being graded on it.
4. **An AI-awareness callout.** A short, factual box on what AI can and cannot do for this specific task.
5. **"What You'll Do Next."** Points the student to that lesson's graded item (a quiz, a notebook entry, or a step toward the module's major assessment).

Nothing in the lesson itself is graded — the grade lives one click downstream, in the linked quiz or assignment.

A typical week

SEGMENT	WHAT THE STUDENT DOES	GRADED?	TIER
1–2 lessons	Read/work through the lesson page(s), including all embedded reflect and practice widgets.	No	—
Notebook/check-in task	A small completion-graded task applying the lesson (a comparison, a plan, a draft) — submitted as a Word doc or Canvas text entry, feeding the module's major assessment.	Yes (completion, 10 pts)	1
Auto-graded quiz	A short comprehension check tied to that week's lesson(s), unlimited or limited attempts.	Yes	1
Discussion (some weeks)	Post a sourced claim or reflection, reply to a peer.	Yes	2
Module wrapper (module start/end only)	A short survey quiz: essential question, confidence rating, and (at the end) a virtue reflection.	Completion	2

Major assessments

ASSESSMENT	MODULE	TIER	WHAT IT ASKS	POINTS
Tool Tour	M1	1	Scavenger hunt across the Career Research Toolkit sites (completion-graded).	15
Industry & Experts Setup	M1	2	Choose an industry, vet 3 experts/sources (SIFT), launch the semester Industry Tracker.	20
AI-Assisted Plan: First Draft	M2	2	Draft a 1-year/5-year plan with the Optima AI account, verified against real sources.	25
Your Path Comparison	M3	3	Researched comparison of the student's own top paths, using real data.	50
Your Resume and Portfolio Piece	M4	3	A real, polished resume as an evolving portfolio artifact.	40
Record Your One-Way Video	M5	3	A recorded one-way video interview response for a real target opportunity.	40
Final Career Plan (course capstone)	M5	2	Reopens and finalizes the Module 2 plan draft, with a "what changed and why" reflection.	30

Grading-time estimate for these seven (per *optima-canvas-assignments* conventions): Tier 2 items run 2–3 minutes each; Tier 3 items (Path Comparison, Resume, One-Way Video) run 5–8 minutes each given rubric use in SpeedGrader — the One-Way Video runs longest since it requires watching the clip.

2. UNGRADED INTERACTIVES & THE INTRO/OUTRO WRAPPERS

Ungraded interactives cost you nothing

Every lesson carries 1–3 small interactive elements: a reflect check-in, a match/select widget, a slider, or a tap-to-reveal / commit-then-reveal accordion. These give the student immediate feedback and **produce no submission** — there is nothing to grade and nothing to chase. A student who skips one shows up indirectly, in weaker quiz or assignment performance, never as a missing grade in your gradebook. Treat them as formation-by-practice: the widget in Lesson 1.2 (match priority to path) is what

makes the graded Path Comparison Check easy; a student who skipped it will struggle on the quiz, and that is the signal to watch, not the widget itself.

The wrappers are Canvas Quizzes in survey mode, not pages

Every module opens and closes with a short wrapper — built as a Canvas Quiz in survey mode so responses come back as sortable cohort data, not free text buried in a page. Each intro wrapper asks the module's essential question and a confidence rating; each outro wrapper re-asks the same question, adds "what's still unclear," and a virtue reflection.

MODULE	ESSENTIAL QUESTION (ASKED AT INTRO, RE-ASKED AT OUTRO)	OUTRO VIRTUE REFLECTION NAMES
1	"What are you trying to build in the years right after high school, and which path do you think gets you there? It is fine not to know yet."	Honesty, perseverance, or responsibility
2	"How is the world of work changing in your field, and what does that change mean for how you should prepare?"	Honesty (facing evidence over hype/fear), perseverance
3	"Which path or two are you most drawn to right now, and what is pulling you toward them?"	(Reflects on the "everything else is a backup plan" framing the module corrects.)
4	"What impression does your 'professional self' give right now, and what do you most want to strengthen?"	Honesty (representing yourself truthfully), courtesy
5	"When it comes to landing an opportunity, what feels hardest to you right now?" — and the course-level question, re-asked verbatim from Module 1: "What are you trying to build after high school, and which path gets you there?"	Honesty, perseverance, responsibility (named as the three virtues asked across the whole course)

Highest-leverage move in the course: spend 15–20 minutes per module triaging outro responses. Watch for clustered low confidence, repeated "still unclear" answers, or a student whose Module 1 and Module 5 answers to the essential question haven't moved at all — that student may need a direct check-in before the semester ends.

3. AI & VR IN THIS COURSE (STUDENT-FACING)

AI

This course teaches AI use directly as one of three standing research habits (look it up / ask AI / ask a person), so its AI posture is more built-out than most Optima courses. 30 of 32 lessons carry a dedicated AI-awareness callout (Lessons 3.5 and 5.4 are the two without one). Do not add new AI requirements of your own.

The consistent posture, in the students' own words from the build: "An AI assistant can speed up your research and draft a first version of a plan in seconds. It cannot decide what you value... Use it to move faster, not to think for you." Every AI-provided fact (pay, cost, outlook, program details) must be verified against a real source before the student relies on it. No specific AI tool is ever required; the AI-Assisted Plan and interview-practice lessons name their own Optima-issued AI account as the default.

VR

VR is **never required** anywhere in this course. Early lessons (1.1, 1.2) mention a VR headset as optional for spatial brainstorming; from Lesson 1.2 onward, nearly every lesson and every Tier 2/3 assignment carries a recurring blue "Where to do this work" box offering VR as one optional workspace alongside notebook, pen and paper, or a Word document. A verbatim example from the AI-Assisted Plan assignment: "Plan wherever you think best, in your notebook, on paper, or in a VR workspace where you can lay out steps on a whiteboard and rearrange them. VR is optional, never required."

4. USING IGNITE AI TO SUPPORT STUDENTS (TEACHER-FACING)

[VERIFY] Ignite AI's exact feature set varies by Canvas release and by what Optima has enabled on your instance. The uses below are described functionally — confirm each is actually turned on before promising it to yourself mid-semester.

Use your Canvas AI assistant (Ignite AI) to make a 500:1 ratio feel personal, in five ways: **draft individualized feedback** on the Tier 3 assessments (you edit and own every word before it's sent); **summarize the outro-wrapper analytics** each module to find the cohort's sticking points fast; **surface students who need a nudge** (a cluster of low confidence on the last outro, a missed Tier 2 item) and draft a warm check-in; **generate a practice variant** for a student who needs another rep on a Tier 1 quiz topic before retaking it; and **draft family communications** when a student is falling behind on pacing.

One flag per module where Ignite AI earns its keep fastest:

- **M1:** after the outro wrapper, ask Ignite AI to summarize confidence-rating clusters — this is your first at-risk signal of the semester.
- **M2:** use it to summarize the "One Honest Claim" discussion thread before grading — 500 posts is a lot to read cold.
- **M3 (heaviest module):** draft individualized feedback on Your Path Comparison from your own rubric marks, then edit — this is your longest grading stretch of the semester.
- **M4:** draft feedback on resume bullets ("strengthen this action verb," "quantify this") to speed turnaround on a document-heavy assessment.
- **M5:** summarize Final Career Plan "what changed and why" reflections across the cohort for a closing announcement that names real growth.

Standing rule: **AI drafts, the teacher decides.** Never let it surveil, rank, or auto-penalize a student; every message sent to a student or family is read, edited, and owned by you first.

5. GRADING CATEGORIES & CANVAS GRADEBOOK SETUP

Assignment groups & weights

GRADING CATEGORY	WEIGHT	WHAT LIVES HERE
Practice & comprehension (Tier 1, auto-graded)	55%	Tool Tour, the 16 Tier-1 quizzes, and the 26 completion check-ins (Section 7 catalog)
Discussions & reflections (Tier 2)	25%	Industry & Experts Setup, AI-Assisted Plan First Draft, Industry-Future discussion, Final Career Plan
Major assessments (Tier 3, teacher-reviewed)	15%	Your Path Comparison, Your Resume and Portfolio Piece, Record Your One-Way Video
Wrappers & participation (completion)	5%	10 module intro/outro survey quizzes

Step-by-step Canvas setup

1. Create the four assignment groups above under *Assignments > group weights*, entering the percentages exactly.
2. Set the grading scheme to standard percentage (no separate letter-grade scale needed for a 0.5-credit elective unless your school requires one).
3. Mark all 10 wrapper quizzes as *Practice Quiz* or *Graded Survey* (Survey mode) so they score as completion, not correctness.

4. Set the late/missing policy to match the syllabus: no per-due-date penalty, a 10% deduction in the final 14 days of the semester, and a zero for anything incomplete at semester end.
5. Turn on *Requirements* / module progress so students (and you) see at-a-glance completion across the ungraded scaffolding.

Gradebook map

ITEM	GROUP	POINTS	METHOD
Tool Tour	Practice & comprehension	15	Completion
Path Comparison Check	Practice & comprehension	[VERIFY] ~10	Auto
Industry & Experts Setup	Discussions & reflections	20	Rubric
Discussion: One Honest Claim	Discussions & reflections	15	Rubric
AI-Assisted Plan: First Draft	Discussions & reflections	25	Rubric
Your Path Comparison	Major assessments	50	Rubric
Your Resume and Portfolio Piece	Major assessments	40	Rubric
Record Your One-Way Video	Major assessments	40	Rubric
Final Career Plan (capstone)	Discussions & reflections	30	Rubric
10 module wrappers (intro + outro × 5)	Wrappers & participation	Completion each	Completion
15 additional Tier-1 quizzes (1 in M2, 7 in M3, 4 in M4, 3 in M5)	Practice & comprehension	10 each	Auto
26 completion check-in assignments (4 in M2, 9 in M3, 7 in M4, 6 in M5)	Practice & comprehension	10 each	Completion

6. RUBRICS FOR EVERY TEACHER-GRADED ITEM

Every Tier 3 item and the two Tier 2 items a teacher reviews closely already carry a full rubric written into the assignment page. Paste each into Canvas as a **native Canvas Rubric** so it scores in SpeedGrader.

INDUSTRY & EXPERTS SETUP · 20 PTS

Industry choice & rationale — 5 · Quality of source vetting (SIFT) — 9 · Complete, usable follow-list — 6

DISCUSSION: ONE HONEST CLAIM ABOUT YOUR INDUSTRY'S FUTURE · 15 PTS

Specific, sourced claim — 7 · Substantive reply to a peer — 5 · Uses module ideas — 3

AI-ASSISTED PLAN: FIRST DRAFT · 25 PTS

Plan grounded in the student's own priorities — 9 · Wise, verified AI use — 10 · Reflection on judgment — 6

YOUR PATH COMPARISON · 50 PTS (STANDARD 4-CRITERIA RUBRIC)

Understanding of the paths — 15 · Quality of reasoning — 15 · Clarity & precision of expression — 10 · Intellectual honesty — 10

YOUR RESUME AND PORTFOLIO PIECE · 40 PTS

Completeness & relevance — 12 · Impact of bullets (action verb + quantified) — 12 · Clarity & formatting — 8 · Honesty & reflection — 8

RECORD YOUR ONE-WAY VIDEO · 40 PTS

Answer content — 14 · Delivery — 12 · Setup & professionalism — 8 · Authenticity & honesty — 6

FINAL CAREER PLAN (COURSE CAPSTONE) · 30 PTS

Concrete, realistic plan — 12 · 1-year-to-5-year coherence — 9 · Growth & honesty (what changed and why) — 9

Tier-1 quizzes and check-in assignments

All 16 Tier-1 quizzes carry their full answer key and per-item feedback in their spec files — nothing to grade by hand. All 26 check-in assignments are completion-graded against the Success Criteria checklist printed on each assignment page; no rubric is needed, only a sincere-attempt judgment. If you ever add a new free-response item, keep to the standard four criteria (**Understanding of the material · Quality of reasoning · Clarity and precision of expression · Intellectual honesty**) so grading stays consistent.

7. DISCUSSIONS, QUIZZES & INTERACTIVE/ASSESSMENT ACTIVITIES

By type

TYPE	HOW IT'S SCORED	RECOMMENDED TEACHER MOVE
Auto-graded quiz	Machine-scored, instant	Spot-check the question bank once per term for stale facts (pay/cost figures age fast); otherwise hands-off.
Structured discussion	Rubric (post + reply)	Batch-read on a simple substantive/thin/missing scale; publicly praise 2–3 strong sourced claims to model good thinking.
Reflection/wrapper survey	Completion	Triage analytics 15–20 min per module (see Section 2); never grade the content of the answer.
Tier 2/3 project	Rubric, SpeedGrader	Use Ignite AI to draft feedback from your rubric marks, then edit and send.

Real-world artifact (One-Way Video)	Rubric, SpeedGrader	Budget extra time per student — you must watch the clip, not just skim text.
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Per-instance: what's built and ready to grade

MODULE	ITEM	TYPE	TIER	GRADING NOTE
1	Tool Tour	Assignment	1	Completion — 4 scavenger-hunt items + bonus for the other two research modes.
1	Path Comparison Check	Quiz	1	7 questions, full answer key + per-item feedback already written into the spec.
1	Industry & Experts Setup	Assignment	2	Rubric in Section 6.
2	One Honest Claim discussion	Discussion	2	Rubric in Section 6; cite a tracked source.
2	AI-Assisted Plan: First Draft	Assignment	2	Rubric in Section 6; file is reopened in M5.
3	Your Path Comparison	Assignment	3	Rubric in Section 6; heaviest single grading stretch of the term.
4	Your Resume and Portfolio Piece	Assignment	3	Rubric in Section 6.
5	Record Your One-Way Video	Assignment	3	Rubric in Section 6; watch the clip in full.
5	Final Career Plan	Assignment	2	Rubric in Section 6; confirm the student actually reopened their M2 draft rather than starting fresh.
1–5	10 module intro/outro wrappers	Survey quiz	2	See Section 2 for the essential-question table.

Per-instance: lesson quizzes and check-ins (all 10 pts each)

MODULE	TIER-1 QUIZZES (AUTO-GRADED; ANSWER KEY IN EACH SPEC FILE)	CHECK-IN ASSIGNMENTS (COMPLETION; SUCCESS CRITERIA ON EACH PAGE)
2	Exposure vs. Job Loss Check (L2.1)	Plan-and-Goal Build (L2.2, Word doc) · Read-and-Capture Task (L2.3, Word doc) · Research-and-Present Task (L2.4, text entry) · Collaboration & Stress Reflection (L2.5, text entry)
3	Four-Year Path · Two-Year Path · Trade & Technical School · Military Path · Work & Gap-Year · Funding Sources · The Money Question (L3.1–3.3, 3.5–3.8)	Compare Two Schools (3.1) · Map a Two-Year Plan (3.2) · Trade-School Program Comparison (3.3) · On-Ramp Research (3.4) · Military Path Notebook Entry (3.5, text entry) · Work & Gap-Year Notebook Entry (3.6, text entry) · My Funding Plan (3.7) · Two Paths Weighed (3.8) · Map My Hometown Opportunity (3.9)
4	Soft Skills & Communication (L4.1) · Adaptability & Planning (L4.2) · Personal Brand (L4.4) · Learning from People (L4.7)	Clear-Instructions Task (4.1) · Reverse-Engineering Roadmap (4.2) · Master Resume Checkpoint (4.3, text entry) · Site Map & Bio Draft (4.4) · Informational Interview Write-Up (4.5) · Online Presence Case Study (4.6) · Outreach Plan (4.7, text entry)

5	Interview Prep (L5.3) · Interview Sequence (L5.5) · First Weeks (L5.6)	Five Openings (5.1) · Apply for a Real Posting (5.2) · STAR Story Draft (5.3, text entry) · Interview Setup Notes (5.4, text entry) · Thank-You Note Draft (5.5) · Job-Seeker Reflection (5.6)
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Quiz specs are *-CANVAS-NATIVE-SPEC.md files in each module folder — build each quiz by hand in Canvas Quizzes from its spec (auto-graded, unlimited attempts). Check-in assignment pages are branded HTML pasted into the Canvas RCE; grade on completion (sincere attempt against the printed Success Criteria). Where a check-in names a Word file, students follow the LastName_FirstName_[ShortName]_CRDM convention from the M365 guide.

8. COACH, NOT CATCH

Your job is to move each student forward, not to detect and punish. In practice:

- Feedback names the next concrete step, not just the error. Lead with what's working before what needs revision.
- Tier 1 quizzes are practice, not a trap — allow re-attempts freely.
- Use outro-wrapper analytics and Ignite AI to find students who need help **early**, then reach out yourself — never to build a case against them.
- On suspected AI misuse (an implausibly polished resume line, a One-Way Video that reads like a script no teenager would write): open a conversation first. Ask the student to talk through their thinking. Treat it as formation, not an accusation.
- Public discussion comments should model good thinking — praise 2–3 strong posts publicly; never single out weak work.

9. WEEKLY ANNOUNCEMENT SCRIPTS

Reusable template

This week you should be in **[Module N, Lesson X]**. The focus is **[one-line topic]**. Don't miss: **[due item and date]**. **[One warm, specific line of encouragement.]** Questions? Office hours are **[day/time]** or message me any time.

Module scripts

MODULE 1 — FOUNDATIONS & YOUR STARTING POINT

Welcome! This module is about taking honest stock of where you are, not deciding your whole future. This week, open your Career Research Toolkit and complete the Tool Tour — it's quick, and it sets up everything else. By [date], you'll also choose the industry you'll track all semester. No wrong choice here; you can always widen your view later.

MODULE 2 — STRATEGY, THINKING & THE CHANGING LANDSCAPE OF WORK

We're looking honestly at how AI is changing work — without the hype or the doom. Your discussion post this week should cite one real, sourced claim about your tracked industry. By [date], you'll also draft the first version of your 1-year/5-year plan with your AI account — remember, AI drafts, you decide.

MODULE 3 — THE PATHS, SIDE BY SIDE (THE LONGEST MODULE)

This is the biggest module of the semester — nine lessons across college, trade school, apprenticeships, military, work, and funding. Pace yourself: aim for about two lessons a week. Your Path Comparison (50 pts) is due [date] and will lean on everything here, so keep good notes as you go.

MODULE 4 — YOUR PROFESSIONAL SELF

Time to build the artifacts you'll actually use: your resume, your online presence, your network. Your Resume and Portfolio Piece is due [date] — start your master resume early so you have time to revise the bullets before submitting.

MODULE 5 — GETTING THE OPPORTUNITY (FINAL MODULE)

Last stretch! This module closes with two real deliverables: your recorded One-Way Video Interview and your Final Career Plan, which reopens the plan you drafted back in Module 2. Look back at how much you've learned since then — it should show.

Situational scripts

MID-MODULE CHECK-IN

If your confidence on the last outro wrapper was low, that's useful information, not a problem. Revisit [specific lesson] or come to office hours this week — a 10-minute conversation usually clears up more than another hour of reading alone.

PRE-MAJOR-ASSESSMENT

[Assessment name] is due [date]. The rubric rewards genuine, specific reasoning over polish — use your own notebook entries from this module as your raw material, and don't wait until the last 14 days to submit; that window carries a 10% deduction.

RE-ENGAGEMENT NUDGE

I haven't seen activity from you in a bit — just checking in. There's no penalty for where you are right now, only for staying stuck. Reply and let me know what's getting in the way, and let's find fifteen minutes to get you moving again.

10. TEACHER WORKFLOW & WORKLOAD MAP

A normal week

1. Triage the current module's wrapper analytics (or last week's, if mid-module) — 15–20 min.
2. Batch-grade any open discussion posts on the substantive/thin/missing scale.
3. Grade any due Tier 2/3 assessment using its rubric in SpeedGrader (use Ignite AI to draft feedback, then edit).
4. Post the week's announcement (see Section 9).
5. Answer student messages and hold office hours.

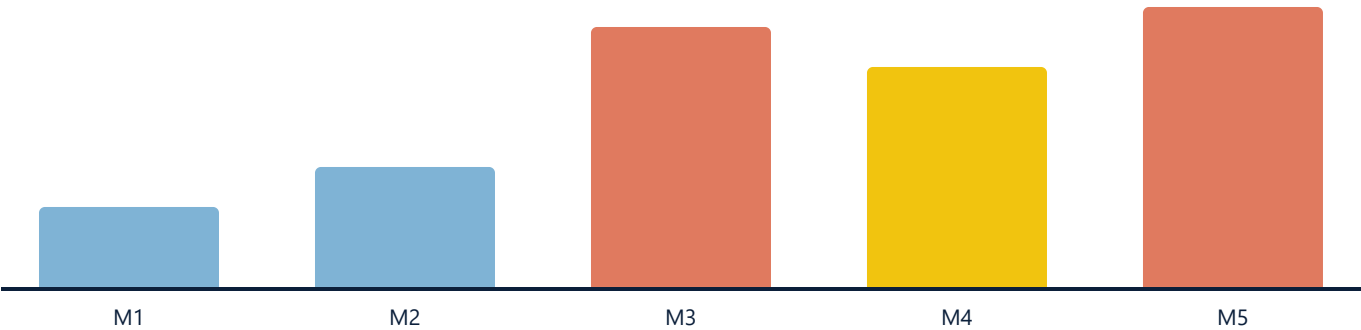
Time budget per *optima-canvas-assignments* convention: roughly 0 hours for Tier 1 (auto-graded), 2–3 hours across the module for Tier 2, and 8–12 hours spread across the module's teaching cycle for a Tier 3 item at full 500-student scale (scale down

proportionally to your actual roster).

Heavy weeks to plan around

- **Module 3** carries the single largest teacher-graded assessment (50 pts) and the most content (9 lessons) — budget extra grading time in its final week.
- **Module 4 and Module 5** both carry document/video-heavy artifacts (resume, one-way video) that take longer per student to review than a written rubric alone would suggest.
- **Module 5's close** stacks two deliverables (One-Way Video + Final Career Plan) in the same final weeks — consider staggering your own grading rather than waiting for both to land at once.

Relative workload by module



Relative facilitator-grading load by module, estimated from tiered item counts and artifact type (blue = light, gold = moderate, coral = heavy). Plan extra time on the coral modules.

11. STANDARDS COVERAGE MAP (CPALMS #1700380)

This course's standards live at the course level, not on any student page, per Optima convention. The full verbatim course-level statement:

"The course addresses the CPALMS #1700380 standards: B.E.S.T. ELA expectations for argumentative and expository writing, research, presentation, and reading (ELA.9.C and ELA.9.R; e.g., the path comparison, the AI plan, the discussion, and the resume/video artifacts); economics and personal finance (SS.912.E: budgeting, credit, ROI, financial institutions, in Module 3); decision-making and problem-solving (SS.912.P.12, throughout); and the seven course outcomes (goal-setting and decision-making, self-assessment, identifying strengths, using career resources, application and interview skills, financial planning and aid, and developing a personal education and career plan)."

No lesson or module README carries more granular per-lesson codes beyond this course-level summary; treat any more specific code as **[VERIFY]** against your school's actual CPALMS crosswalk before reporting it to an administrator.

By standard

STANDARD	WHERE IT'S TAUGHT	WHERE IT'S ASSESSED
ELA.9.C / ELA.9.R (argumentative & expository writing, research, presentation, reading)	Throughout, most concentrated in M2 (research/presentation, L2.3–L2.4) and M3	Discussion (M2), Your Path Comparison (M3), AI Plan draft/final (M2, M5), Resume (M4), One-Way Video (M5, oral)

SS.912.E (economics & personal finance)	Module 3, Lessons 3.7 (Funding the Path) and 3.8 (The Money Question)	Your Path Comparison (M3); My Funding Plan check-in (L3.7, 10 pts); Two Paths Weighed check-in (L3.8, 10 pts); Funding Sources and Money Question quizzes
SS.912.P.12 (decision-making & problem-solving)	All five modules — the five decision questions (M1), strategy tools (M2), path evaluation (M3), professional decisions (M4), opportunity decisions (M5)	Path Comparison Check, Your Path Comparison, Final Career Plan

By module (quick reference)

MODULE	COURSE OUTCOMES IT CARRIES
1 — Foundations & Your Starting Point	Self-assessment; identifying strengths; using career resources (launches the Toolkit habit); goal-setting & decision-making (the five questions)
2 — Strategy, Thinking & the Changing Landscape of Work	Goal-setting & decision-making (Eisenhower/SMART); developing a personal education/career plan (first draft); research & presentation skills
3 — The Paths, Side by Side	Using career resources (heaviest module for this); financial planning & aid; decision-making applied to a real personal choice
4 — Your Professional Self	Identifying strengths (resume); application skills (resume/portfolio foundation); using career resources (networking)
5 — Getting the Opportunity	Application & interview skills; developing a personal education/career plan (capstone, finalized)

12. WHAT MAKES THIS COURSE CLASSICAL & CULTIVATING CULTURE

What makes it classical

This course doesn't teach a great-books text, but it carries the same intellectual habits Optima's classical approach asks of every subject: **go to the primary source**. Lesson 1.3's SIFT/lateral-reading method and the standing "look it up / ask AI / ask a person" framework are, in substance, the same discipline of verifying a claim against its original rather than trusting secondhand authority that a Latin or history course asks of a text. The virtue thread is explicit and structural, not decorative: every module's outro wrapper names the specific virtue that module actually asked of the student (honesty in self-assessment and source-vetting, perseverance in the uncertain-path work of Module 1 and the heaviest module, Module 3, courtesy in the real networking of Module 4, responsibility in owning a plan through to Module 5's capstone). The course's founding premise — that meaningful work is part of a meaningful life — is the vocational half of Optima's Portrait of a Graduate made concrete and actionable rather than left as an abstraction.

Cultivating culture asynchronously

- Praise 2–3 strong, specific discussion posts publicly each module rather than critiquing weak ones in public.
- Use the Module 1 → Module 5 essential-question bookend as a real moment of reflection in your own final announcement — name what actually changed for the cohort, not just for individuals.
- Treat the weekly announcement as a real relationship touchpoint: curiosity about the field a student is tracking, not just a checklist reminder.
- Model the "ask a person" habit yourself — mention your own real conversations or research in announcements so the course's third research mode feels lived, not theoretical.

13. SENSITIVE-CONTENT FLAGS & FAMILY/STUDENT SCRIPTS

This course is deliberately neutral and low-risk on contested topics. The flags below are genuine but minor; most need only a facilitator's awareness, not a family-facing script.

WHERE	WHAT	RECOMMENDED HANDLING
Lesson 2.4	One abstract, unnamed political-party fallacy example ("Policy X... other political party...") — no real party, politician, or policy named.	No script needed; be ready to note it's a logic example, not a political statement, if a student asks.
Lesson 3.5	Military Service, explicitly non-recruiting in tone.	No script needed; the lesson itself states "not to recruit you and not to talk you out of it."
Lessons 3.7–3.8	Funding/ROI lessons deliberately hold "more education pays on average" against "payoff isn't guaranteed" in tension — by design, not an oversight.	No script needed; this is the intended even-handed framing.
Lessons 4.5, 4.7	Students reach out to real adults for informational interviews (routed through warm introductions, not cold contact). No explicit parental-notice clause in student text.	Send the family script below before Module 4 begins.
Assignment 5 (One-Way Video)	Students record and submit a real personal video. No explicit statement of who can view it or how it's stored.	Send the privacy script below when the assignment opens.
Lesson 4.6	Requires researching a real news case of social media affecting someone professionally.	Skim what real-world examples students surface before any class discussion of them.

FAMILY SCRIPT — INFORMATIONAL INTERVIEWS (SEND BEFORE MODULE 4)

In the next few weeks, your student will be asked to reach out to someone they know — or someone you know — for a short conversation about that person's career or life path. This is a real-world networking skill we teach explicitly: how to ask for a brief conversation, what to ask, and how to follow up with a thank-you. Students are directed to go through a warm introduction (someone they or their family already knows), not to contact strangers cold. If you'd like to suggest someone, or if you have any questions about this assignment, please reach out. [Teacher: add your contact info.]

PRIVACY SCRIPT — THE ONE-WAY VIDEO ASSIGNMENT (SEND WHEN MODULE 5 OPENS)

Later this module, your student will record a short one-way video interview response, similar to what real employers now use in hiring. The recording is submitted privately through Canvas and is viewed only by me, for the purpose of grading and feedback — it is not shared publicly or with other students. Please have your student record in a quiet, appropriate space. Questions are always welcome. [Teacher: add your contact info.]

14. ADAPTING TO A LIVE, 4-DAY-PER-WEEK SCHEDULE

This course was designed fully asynchronous, so nothing below changes the content — it only resequences the same 5 modules, 32 lessons, and 7 major assessments into a live, in-person or synchronous-VR rhythm that meets 4 days a week across roughly 18 weeks. Content and rubrics stay identical to the On-Demand build; only the pacing and the "who leads it" changes.

The weekly rhythm to reuse every week

DAY	LIVE CLASS DOES
Day 1	Introduce the week's first lesson as a group: read the opening hook together, discuss the reflect check-in out loud before students click through it individually.
Day 2	Guided work time on that lesson's interactive widgets and notebook entry; circulate for one-on-one help; this is your best moment to catch confusion before it compounds.
Day 3	Introduce the week's second lesson (when the module has one) the same way as Day 1, or move straight to assignment work time in lighter weeks.
Day 4	Work day and office hours: students finish notebook entries, start the module's graded item, ask questions. Close with a 5-minute verbal check-in mirroring the wrapper's essential question.

Module-by-module week map

WK	MODULE	DAY 1	DAY 2	DAY 3	DAY 4
1	M1 · Foundations	Intro wrapper + L1.1 Course Intro (group discuss the 3 semester projects)	L1.0 Toolkit; start Tool Tour	Finish & submit Tool Tour	L1.2 What Are You Optimizing For (group discuss the six paths)
2		Path Comparison Check (in class, individually)	L1.3 Find Your Industry & Experts (model SIFT together on one example)	Work day: draft Industry & Experts Setup	Peer-share industry choices; submit Industry & Experts Setup
3		L1.4 Taking Personal Stock (guided self-inventory)	Work day: notebook entries	Module 1 outro wrapper + group discussion	Preview Module 2 / office hours
4	M2 · Strategy & Thinking	L2.1 Work in a Time of AI (group discuss optimistic vs. cautionary views)	Work day: Industry-Future discussion draft	L2.2 Time Management (model Eisenhower Matrix live)	Work day: Plan-and-Goal Build; post discussion
5		L2.3 Active Reading & Note-Taking (practice Cornell notes together on a real article)	Work day: Read-and-Capture Task	L2.4 Critical Thinking & Research (group source-evaluation exercise)	Work day: Research-and-Present Task; reply to a peer's discussion post
6		L2.5 Collaboration & Managing Stress (group stress-reset practice)	Work day: start AI-Assisted Plan First Draft	Continue AI Plan draft; office hours for AI-account questions	Module 2 outro wrapper; submit AI Plan First Draft

7	M3 · The Paths, Side by Side (heaviest module — plan for two lessons most weeks)	Intro wrapper + L3.1 Four-Year College	L3.2 Two-Year College	Work day: compare-two-schools / map-a-two-year-plan tasks	L3.3 Trade & Technical School
8		L3.4 Apprenticeships & Earn-While-You-Learn	Work day: on-ramp research; start earning a microcredential	L3.5 Military Service	L3.6 Straight to Work & Gap Year
9		L3.7 Funding the Path (bring in a real net-price-calculator example)	Work day: My Funding Plan	L3.8 The Money Question	Work day: Two Paths Weighed
10		L3.9 Opportunity in My Hometown	Work day: Map My Hometown Opportunity	Work day: start Your Path Comparison	Work day: continue Your Path Comparison
11		Work day: finish Your Path Comparison	Peer-share (voluntary) path comparisons	Module 3 outro wrapper + group discussion	Submit Your Path Comparison; preview Module 4
12	M4 · Your Professional Self	Intro wrapper + L4.1 Soft Skills & Communication	L4.2 Adaptability & Reverse-Engineering Goals (model the 4-step backward walk)	L4.3 Resume & Portfolio (start master resume)	Work day: resume bullets, action verbs, quantifying
13		L4.4 Personal Brand & Website	Work day: site map / bio draft	L4.5 Networking as Strategy (practice an outreach message together)	Work day: build contact tracker
14		L4.6 Social Media & Online Presence (footprint-audit exercise)	L4.7 Learning from People (build the question bank together)	Module 4 outro wrapper; work day on resume	Submit Your Resume and Portfolio Piece

15	M5 · Getting the Opportunity (final module)	Intro wrapper + L5.1 Searching for Work	L5.2 Applying: Standing Out on Paper	Work day: apply for a real posting; update tracker	L5.3 Practicing Interviews with AI (rehearse a STAR story aloud)
16		L5.4 The One-Way Video Interview (setup checklist — lighting, background, device)	Work day: record and submit One-Way Video	L5.5 The Interview and Follow-Up (practice the thank-you note)	Work day: office hours
17		L5.6 The First Day and Beyond	Work day: start reopening the Module 2 plan draft for the Final Career Plan	Continue Final Career Plan	Continue Final Career Plan; peer-share growth reflections (voluntary)
18		Finish & submit Final Career Plan	Module 5 outro / course wrap-up wrapper (in class, as a group conversation)	Course closing conversation: revisit each student's Module 1 answer to "what are you trying to build"	Buffer / makeup day

Two adjustments a live facilitator will likely make in practice: (1) in Module 3's five weeks, some groups will want three live days on content and only one work day — watch pacing against the Your Path Comparison due date rather than following the map rigidly; (2) the Tier-1 quizzes and completion check-ins cataloged in Section 7 slot naturally into the "work day" blocks above — the quizzes make quick individual openers or closers on a live day, and the check-ins are exactly what the work-day slots are for.